Collins COBUILD English Grammar, 4the edition (2017)

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March 28, 2021

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0.1 About COBUILD

When the 1st COBUILD dictionary was published in 1987, it revolutionized dictionaries for learners.

It was the 1st of the new generation of language reference materials that were based on actual evidence of how English was used, rather than lexicographer intuition.

Collins and the University of Birmingham, led by the linguist John Sinclair, developed an electronic corpus in 1980s, called the Collins Birmingham University International Language Database (COBUILD).

This corpus, which for several years was known as the Bank of English©, became the largest collection of English data in the world.

COBUILD dictionary editors use the corpus to analyze the way that people really use the language.

The Collins Corpus now contains 4.5 billion words taken from websites, newspapers, magazines and books published around the world, and from spoken material from radio, TV and everyday conversations.

New data is added to the corpus every month, to help COBUILD editors identify new words, grammatical structures, and meanings from the moment they are 1st used.

All COBUILD language reference books are based on the information their editors find the Collins Corpus.

Because the corpus is so large, their editors can look at lots of examples of how people really use the language.

The data tells them how the language is used; the function of different structures; which words are used together; and how often these words and structures are used.

All of the examples in COBUILD language materials are examples of real English, taken from the corpus.

The examples have been carefully chosen to demonstrate typical grammatical patterns, typically vocabulary and typical contexts.

COBUILD English Grammar is no exception: Collins editors and researchers have been able to use this wealthy of information to establish a unique and full description of English grammar, and to track the development of certain grammatical structures over time.

The corpus lies at the heart of COBUILD, and you can be confident that COBUILD will show you what you need to know to be able to communicate easily and accurately in English.

To learn more about COBUILD and the Collins Corpus, go to `www.collinselt.com` and click on 'COBUILD Reference'.

0.2 Introduction

This grammar is suitable for anyone who is interested in the English language and how it works in everyday current contexts.

It has been written mainly for advanced-level students and their teachers, but any serious learner will find it a valuable reference tool.

The information in this book is taken from a long and careful study of present-day English involving the analysis of the Collins Corpus - a corpus of many millions of words of speech and writing.

0.2.1 A functional approach

Most people who study and use a language are interested in how they can *do things* with the language - how they can make meanings, get attention, influence people, and learn about the world.

They are interested in the grammatical structure of the language as a way of getting things done.

A grammar that puts together the patterns of the language and the things you can do with them is called a *functional grammar*.

This is a functional grammar; that is to say, it is based on the important relation between structure and function.

Each chapter is built around a major function of language, e.g. *describing people and things*, and *reporting what someone said*.

Each of these functions is regularly expressed in English by particular structures.

E.g., describing people and things is usually expressed by adjectives, and reporting what people say or think typically involves a reporting verb e.g. *say*, followed by a clause beginning with *that* or a clause with quotation marks (‘ ’) around it.

This grammar follows up each major statement (often called a *rule* in other grammars) with a detailed description of the uses surrounding it - including any exceptions.

The scope of the original function may then be extended.

E.g., the basic, central function of reporting verbs (Chap. 7) is to state what someone has said.

Example 0.2.1. *He said he would be back soon.*

It can be easily be extended to include what someone has written.

Example 0.2.2. *His mother wrote that he had finally arrived home.*

Then it can be widened to include thoughts and feelings; these do not need to be expressed in words, but the reporting structure is very convenient.

Example 0.2.3. *The boys thought he was dead.*

From this we can see the reporting clause as a more general way of introducing another clause.

Examples

All the examples in this book are taken from the Collins Corpus.

As ever, the corpus lies at the heart of each grammar point described, helping compilers to make confident and accurate decisions about different structures and usage.

Examples themselves remain close to the corpus, with minor changes made so that they are more accessible to the learner.

They are carefully chosen so as to illustrate typical patterns and collocations in real-life situations.

0.2.2 Groups of words that behave in the same way

As well as providing a wealth of illustrative examples, this book gives further information about the grammar of a large number of specific words.

The actual words and phrases that are regularly used in each structure are given in a series of lists.

In this way, the learner can get a good idea of how large or small a grammatical class is, and how many words a certain rule applies to.

Wherever there is good reason to do so, the words and phrases are grouped together in a list in a meaningful arrangement.

So, e.g., at [1.21], separate groups are set in a single list, including animals, fish, words ending in *-craft*, and foreign words ending in *-s*.

These all share the same feature, i.e. that they can be either singular or plural nouns without any change in form - *moose, salmon, aircraft, corps*.

From a purely grammatical point of view, they could all go in a single alphabetical list; however from a teaching and learning point of view, it is helpful to have them further classified according to their meaning.

0.2.3 ‘Be creative’

Certain areas of English grammar are very flexible and *productive*.

Some are well known, e.g. the fact that almost any noun in English can modify another noun.

E.g., the noun *steam* can be used in, among others, the following combinations: *steam bath, steam room, steam engine, steam iron, steam power*, and *steam train*.

With this in mind, several ‘Be creative’ features are included to encourage learners to use their imagination, and to be more confident about expressing themselves.

In such cases, rather than giving a definite rule, the authors prefer to give guidance so that the user can make individual choices with no serious risk of error.

By describing the language in this way, give plenty of scope for creativity and innovation.

0.2.4 Accessibility

When using a grammar, it can be difficult to find the information that you want.

This is often the biggest single problem for users of grammars, and a good reason why grammars are often unpopular with learners.

This grammar makes a special effort to support the user.

The authors have aimed to use the most up-to-date and commonly used grammatical terminology throughout.

Technical terms have been used only where there is no obvious alternative.

A glossary of terms is provided and they are also all listed in the index.

There is a contents list at the beginning of the book, and there is an individual contents list at the beginning of each chapter.

Using these of the index, the user will be able to find the section or paragraph where a function is associated with a structure.

Throughout the book there are paragraph headings that show the topic of almost every paragraph, and there are frequent additional headings for each section of a chapter.

At the top of each page, there is another heading to guide the user.

0.2.5 New developments in language

The continued development of the corpus enables us to keep us with the ever-changing nature of language.

At COBUILD, the authorscontinually track and research the development of grammatical features, e.g.:

(i) the use of the progressive with so-called stative verbs (e.g. *I'm loving every minute of it*)

(ii) the use of *much* in affirmative unmodified statements (e.g. *There was much debate*)

(iii) the spread of generic pronouns (e.g. *You get some people who are very difficult*)

(iv) the use of *like* in reporting structures (e.g. *And I was like, 'wow!'*)

(v) the use of all-purpose question tags in some varieties of spoken informal English (e.g. *innit*)

The results are often fascinating and surprising, and enable us to ensure that each new edition of the Grammar gives you a clear portrayal of real English as it is written and spoken today.

0.2.6 The grammar of business & academic English

An extension of our functional approach has been to focus on 2 main contexts in which English is used as a lingua franca throughout the world - business and academic English.

As a result, 2 supplementary sections identify the principal areas of grammar that learners need to master if they wish to communicate effectively in business and academic contexts.

The section on the grammar of business English looks at typical structures used in such contexts as sharing information, negotiating, and giving presentations.

The academic English section covers such areas as explaining results, reviewing research, and reporting findings.

Extensive cross-referencing allows the user to refer back to the main text, where structures are discussed in greater detail.

The authors hope that you will enjoy learning about English grammar from a functional perspective - from exploring the wealth of real-world examples of current language, to understanding how certain structures work in business and academic contexts.

The authors hope, too, that as a result, you will gain the confidence to use English creatively and effectively in a wide range of everyday situations.

0.2.7 Getting the most out of COBUILD English Grammar

Would you like to discover more about the wealth of information COBUILD English Grammar has to offer, and explore the subject of grammar further?

If so, go to www.collinselt.com/cobuildenglishgrammar, where you will find a range of blogposts, written by experts in the field, that encourage focused thinking and discussion with your peers on a variety of topics, e.g.:

- questioning traditionally accepted grammar 'rules'
- establishing the difference between nonstandard usage and errors
- thinking about why some people avoid using the word 'tense' to talk about perfect and progressive forms.

To help you examine each topic in turn in greater detail, each blogpost has a link to a corresponding worksheet.

0.3 How to use this Grammar

The COBUILD English Grammar is designed to be used both for quick reference and for in-depth study.

0.3.1 Organization of the main text

The main text of the Grammar is divided into 10 chapters.

The 1st 2 chapters deal with the noun phrase, Chaps. 3–5 with the verb phrase.

Chap. 6 deals with adverbs and prepositions, Chap. 7 with reporting, Chap. 8 with joining words, phrases and clauses, and Chaps. 9–10 with continuous text.

Each chapter consists of a series of main topics and each topic is divided into sections.

Paragraphs in the chapter are numbered, so that Chap. 1 runs from **1.1** to **1.251**, Chap. 2 from **2.1** to **2.302** and so on.

This numbering system makes it easy for the user to refer to different but related points.

There are cross-references throughout the text, either pointing to the main place where a topic is dealt with or to another paragraph where more information is given.

Most paragraphs also have a heading, saying in a few words what it deals with, especially which grammatical structure is being explained.

Some paragraph headings do not show specifically what the paragraph deals with, but indicate information of a different kind.

These paragraphs have the headings 'Be careful,' 'Be Creative', and 'Usage Note'.

[!] 'Be Careful' highlights points where people often have problems with a particular grammatical feature of English, e.g. because it is a feature where English is different from many other languages.

[⋆] 'Be Creative' indicates that the rule that has been mentioned can be applied in English to a very large number of words.

E.g., it is nearly always possible to make the *-ing* participle of a verb into an adjective that is used in front of a noun.

By taking note of these features, you can use the rules that have been presented in a creative and original way, giving you greater freedom to express yourself in English.

'Be Creative' features are explained in greater detail in the Introduction.

[i] 'Usage Note' gives information about the use of individual words or small groups of words.

This information is important but cannot be generalized into a grammatical rule.

The Usage Notes help you to understand points that are important for the understanding of particular words, rather than points that relate to large numbers of words.

The U.S. flag symbol highlights paragraphs containing information about typical American English usage.

The speech bubble symbol identifies paragraphs describing structures that are most commonly found in spoken English.

Most of the grammatical explanations are followed by examples showing how the structure is used.

These examples are all taken from the Collins Corpus, and show how the structures are used naturally in speech or writing.

The examples therefore give important information about typical use of a structure, the words it is frequently used with, and the contexts in which it is likely to occur.

Throughout the book, grammatical explanations are followed by lists of the words that typically illustrate that grammatical point.

E.g., in Chap. 3, the point is made that many verbs can be either transitive or intransitive with the same meaning.

This is followed by a list of verbs that are frequently used in this way.

The lists go beyond the actual examples of use that are given, to other words that behave in similar ways.

They show whether the point being made can be applied to a small number or a large number of words.

If the group is small, all members of it are given.

If the group is large, then the most frequently used words are given.

These lists can be used to help you increase your vocabulary and to check that you are using newly learned English words correctly.

0.3.2 Additional contents

In addition to the main text, various other sections are included to help you to get the most out of this Grammar.

These additional sections are described below.

0.3.2.1 Glossary of grammatical terms

The Glossary explains the meaning of grammatical terms.

It covers the terms that are used in this grammar, and also includes terms that are used in other grammars, with a cross-reference to the term used in this book, where appropriate.

E.g., this grammar talks about the *present progressive*, whereas some other grammars call it the *present continuous*.

Both of these terms are mentioned in the Glossary, with the explanation being given at *present progressive*.

0.3.2.2 Reference section

This section at the back of the book provides an easy-to-use reference guide that shows how the following groups of words are formed:

- plurals of nouns
- the comparative and superlative of adjectives
- '-ly' adverbs formed from adjectives
- the comparative and superlative of adverbs
- tenses
- other verb forms
- passives
- principal parts of irregular verbs

The Reference section also includes other topics.

E.g., it starts with a pronunciation guide, to remind you of the sounds of English.

There are also lists of numbers, and an explanation of how numbers are expressed aloud.

0.3.2.3 The grammar of business & academic English

These sections provide key guidance in the principal areas of grammar that learners need to master for effective communication in business and academic contexts.

0.3.2.4 Index

The Index is a comprehensive list of everything dealt with in the Grammar.

It covers:

- the grammatical and functional topics dealt with in the Grammar;
- individual words which are used as examples of a particular grammatical point;
- grammatical terms, both those used in this book and those commonly used in other books.

0.4 Glossary of grammatical terms

1. **abstract noun**: a noun used to describe a quality, idea, or experience rather than something physical or concrete; e.g., *joy, size, language*.

   Cf. **concrete noun**.

2. **active**: used for describing verb phrases e.g. *gives*, and *has made*, where the subject is the person or thing doing the action or responsible for the action.

   Cf. **passive**.

3. **adjectival clause**: another name for **relative clause**.
4. **adjective**: a word used to tell yu more about a thing, e.g. its appearance, color, size, or other qualities; e.g., ... *a pretty blue dress.*
5. **adverb**: a word that gives more information about when, how, where, or in what circumstances something happens; e.g. *quickly, now.*

   There are several different kinds of adverb; adverbs of degree, manner, place, time, duration, and frequency.

   There are also **focusing adverbs**.
6. **adverbial**: a word or combination of words added to a clause to give more information about time, place, or manner.

   See also **sentence adverbial** and **sentence connector**.
7. **adverb of degree**: an adverb indicating the amount or extent of a feeling or quality; e.g. *extremely.*
8. **adverb/adverbial of duration**: an adverb or adverbial indicating how long something lasts; e.g. *briefly, for a long time.*
9. **adverb/adverbial of frequency**: an adverb or adverbial indicating how often something happens; e.g. *often, once a week.*
10. **adverb of manner**: an adverb indicating the way in which something happens or is done; e.g. *carefully.*
11. **adverb of place**: an adverb that gives more information about position or direction; e.g. *Move closer.*
12. **adverb particle**: an adverb used as part of a phrasal verb; e.g. *hide out, sit up, turn round.*
13. **affirmative**: not containing a negative word.

    Also called **positive**.
14. **agent**: another name for **performer**.
15. **agreement**: the relationship between a subject and its verb, or between a number or determiner and its noun; e.g. *I look/she looks... 1 bell/3 bells.*

    Also called **concord**.
16. **apostrophe s**: an ending ('s) added to a noun to mark possession; e.g. ... *Harriet's daughter... the professor's husband... the Managing Director's secretary.*
17. **article**: see **definite article**, **indefinite article**.
18. **aspect**: the use of verb forms to show whether an action is continuing, repeated, or finished.
19. **attributive**: used for describing the position of adjectives when they are used in front of a noun.

    Cf. **predicative**.
20. **auxiliary verb**: 1 of the verbs *be, have*, and *do* when they are used with a main verb to make verb forms, negatives, questions, and so on.

    Also called **auxiliary**.

    Modals are also auxiliary verbs.
21. **bare infinitive**: another name for **infinitive without to**.
22. **base form**: the form of a verb that has no letters added to the end and is not a past form; e.g. *walk, go, have, be.*

    The base form is the form you look up in a dictionary.
23. **broad negative**: 1 of a small group of adverbs including *barely* and *seldom* which are used to make a statement almost negative; e.g. *I barely knew her.*
24. **cardinal number**: a number used for counting; e.g. *one, seven, nineteen.*
25. **classifying adjective**: an adjective used to identity something as being of particular type; e.g. *Indian, wooden, mental.*

    They do not have comparatives or superlatives.

    Cf. **qualitative adjective**.

26. **clause**: a group of words containing a verb.

    See also **main clause** and **subordinate clause**.

27. **clause of manner**: a subordinate clause that describes the way in which something is done, usually introduced with *as* or *like*; e.g. *She talks like her mother used to.*

28. **collective noun**: a noun that refers to a group of people or things; e.g. *committee, team.*

29. **color adjective**: an adjective referring to a color; e.g. *red, blue, scarlet.*

30. **common noun**: a noun used to refer to a person, thing, or substance; e.g. *sailor, computer, glass.*

    Cf. **proper noun**.

31. **comparative**: an adjective or adverb with *-er* on the end or *more* in front of it; e.g. *friendlier, more important, more carefully.*

32. **complement**: a noun phrase or adjective that comes after a linking verb e.g. *be*, and gives more information about the subject or object of the clause; e.g. *She is a teacher, She is tired, They made her chairperson.*

33. **complex sentence**: a sentence consisting of 2 or more main clauses linked by a subordinating conjunction; e.g. *We went inside when it started to rain.*

34. **compound**: a combination of 2 or more words functioning as a unit.

    E.g., *self-centered* and *free-style* are compound adjectives, *bus stop* and *state of affairs* are compounds nouns, and *dry-clean* and *roller-skate* are compound verbs.

35. **compound sentence**: a sentence consisting of 2 or more main clauses linked by a coordinating conjunction; e.g. *They picked her up and took her into the house.*

36. **concessive clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *although* or *while*, that contrasts with a main clause; e.g. *Although I like her, I find her hard to talk to.*

37. **concord**: another name for **agreement**.

38. **concrete noun**: a noun that refers to something we can touch or see; e.g. *table, dress, flower.*

    Cf. **abstract noun**.

39. **conditional clause**: a subordinate clause usually starting with *if.*

    The event described in the main clause depends on the condition described in the subordinate clause; e.g. *If it rains, we'll go to the cinema.*

    They would be rich if they had taken my advice.

40. **conjunction**: a word linking together 2 clauses, phrases, or words.

    There are 2 types of conjunction - **coordinating conjunctions**, which link parts of a sentence of the same grammatical type (*and, but, or*), and **subordinating conjunctions**, which begin subordinate clauses (*although, when*).

41. **continuous**: another name for **progressive**.

42. **contraction**: a shortened form in which an auxiliary verb and *not*, or a subject and an auxiliary verb, are joined together and functions as 1 word; e.g. *aren't, she's.*

43. **coordinate clause**: a clause that is connected to another clause with a coordinating conjunction e.g. *and or but*; e.g. *He fell and broke his leg.*

44. **coordinating conjunction**: a word e.g. *and, but*, or *or* which joins together 2 clauses, phrases, or words of the same grammatical type.

45. **copula**: a name sometimes used to refer to the verb *be.*

    In this grammar, the term **linking verb** is used.

46. **countable noun**: a noun that can be singular or plural; e.g. *dog/dogs, lemon/lemons, foot/feet.*

    Also called **count noun**.

47. **declarative**: a clause in the declarative form has the subject followed by the verb.

    Most statements are made in the declarative form.

    Also called **indicative**.

48. **defining non-finite clause**: a participle clause that is placed after a noun phrase to identify the person or thing you are talking about; e.g. *The girl wearing the red hat.*

49. **defining relative clause**: a relative clause that identifies the person or thing that is being talked about; e.g. *I wrote down everything that she said.*

50. **definite article**: the determiner '*the*'.

51. **delexical verb**: a verb that has very little meaning in itself and is used with an object that carries the main meaning of the structure.

    Give, have, and *take* are commonly used as delexical verbs; e.g. *She gave a small cry.*

    I've had a bath.

52. **demonstrative**: 1 of the words *this, that, these*, and *those* used in front of a noun; e.g. ... *this woman... that tree.*

    They are also used as pronouns; e.g. *That looks nice... This is fun.*

53. **dependent clause**: another name for **subordinate clause**.

54. **definite determiner**: 1 of a groups of determiners including *the, that* and *your* which you use when the person you are speaking to understands which person or thing you are talking about; e.g. *the old man, my ideas.*

55. **determiner**: 1 of a group of words including *the, a, some*, and *my* which are used at the beginning of a noun phrase.

56. **direct object**: a noun phrase referring to a person or thing affected by an action, in a sentence with an active verb; e.g. *She wrote her name... I shut the windows.*

57. **direct speech**: speech reported in the words actually spoken by someone, without any changes in tense, person, and so on.

58. **ditransitive verb**: a verb e.g. *give, take*, or *sell* which can have both an indirect and a direct object; e.g. *She gave me a kiss.*

59. **dynamic verb**: a verb e.g. *run, give* or *slice* which describes an action.

    Cf. **stative verb**.

60. ***-ed* adjective**: an adjective that ends in *-ed*, and usually has the same form as the *-ed* participle of a verb, or is formed by adding *-ed* to a noun; e.g. *a worried look... skilled workers.*

    Adjectives that do not end in *-ed* but have the same forms as irregular *-ed* participles are also called *-ed* adjectives; e.g. a *broken* bone.

61. ***-ed* particle**: a verb form e.g. *walked* or *played*, which is used to make perfect forms and passives, or in some cases an adjective.

    Irregular participles e.g. *given* and *broken* are also called *-ed* participles because they behave like regular *-ed* participles.

    Also called **past participle**.

62. **ellipsis**: when you leave out words because they are obvious from the context.

63. **emphasizing adjective**: an adjective e.g. *complete, utter* or *total* which stresses how strongly you feel about something; e.g. *I feel a complete fool.*

64. **ergative verb**: a verb that can be either transitive or intransitive in the same meaning.

    To use the verb intransitively, you use the object of the transitive verb as the subject of the intransitive verb; e.g. *He had boiled a kettle... The kettle had boiled.*

65. **exclamation**: a word or sentence spoken suddenly and loudly in order to express surprise, anger, and so on; e.g. *Oh gosh!*

66. **finite**: a finite verb is inflected according to person or tense rather than being an infinitive or a participle.

67. **first person**: see **person**.

68. **focusing adverb**: a sentence adverb that indicates the most relevant thing involved; e.g. *only, mainly, especially.*

69. **future**: the use of *will* or *shall* with the base form of the verb to refer to future events; e.g. *She will come tomorrow.*

70. **future progressive**: the use of *will be* or *shall be* and an *-ing* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *She will be going soon.*

    Also called **future continuous**.

71. **future perfect**: the use of *will have* or *shall have* and an *-ed* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *I shall have finished tomorrow.*

72. **future perfect progressive**: the use of *will* or *shall* with *have been* and an *-ing* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *I will have been walking for 3 hours by then.*

    Also called **future perfect continuous**.

73. **gender**: a grammatical term referring to the difference between masculine and feminine words e.g. *he* and *she.*

74. **generic pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *you* and *they* which are used to refer to people in general.

75. **gerund**: another name for ***-ing* noun**.

76. **gradable**: a gradable adjective can be used with a word e.g. *very* to say that the person or thing referred to has more or less of a quantity; e.g. *very boring, less helpful.*

77. **idiom**: a group of 2 or more words with a meaning that cannot be understood by taking the meaning of each individual word; e.g. *to kick the bucket, to run wild.*

78. ***if*-clause**: a **conditional clause**; or a clause used to report a *yes/no*-question.

79. **imperative**: a clause in the imperative has the base form of the verb without a subject, e.g. *Come here... Take 2 tablets every 4 hours... Enjoy yourself.*

80. **impersonal**: ***it*** is an impersonal subject when it is used to introduce a fact, or when it is used in a split sentence; e.g. *It's raining... It was you who asked.*

81. **indefinite article**: the determiners *a* and *an.*

82. **indefinite determiner**: 1 of a group of determiners including *a, many* and *several* which you use to refer to someone or something of a particular type, without saying which person or thing you mean; e.g. *an old man, several suggestions.*

83. **indefinite place adverb**: 1 of a group of adverbs including *anywhere* and *somewhere* which are used to indicate position or location in a general or vague way.

84. **indefinite pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *someone* and *anything* which are used to refer to a person or thing in a generaly way.

85. **indicative**: another name for **declarative**.

86. **indirect object**: a 2nd object used with a transitive verb to indicate who or what benefits from an action, or gets something as a result of it; e.g. *She gave me a rose.*

87. **indirect question**: a way of asking a question that makes it sound more polite; e.g. *Can you tell me where the bank is?* instead of *Where is the bank?*

88. **indirect speech**: another name for **reported speech**.

89. **infinitive**: the base form of a verb.

    It is often used with *to* in front of it; e.g. *(to) take, (to) see, (to) bring.*

90. **infinitive without to**: the infinitive form without *to* in front of it, used with modals and certain other verbs; e.g. *You must go... Let me think.*

91. **inflection**: the variation in the form of a word to show differences in tense, number, case, and degree.

92. ***-ing* adjective**: an adjective that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb; e.g. *... a smiling face... a winning streak.*

93. ***-ing* participle**: a verb form ending in *-ing* that is used to make verb forms, and as an adjective.

    Also called the **present participle**.

94. ***-ing* noun**: a noun that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb; e.g. *Swimming is good for you.*

95. **interjection**: another name for **exclamation**.

96. **interrogative adverb**: 1 of the adverbs *how, when, where*, and *why* when they are used to ask questions.

97. **interrogative**: a clause in the interrogative form has part or all of the verb phrase in front of the subject.

    Most questions are asked in the interrogative form.

98. **interrogative pronoun**: 1 of the pronouns *who, whose, whom, what*, and *which* when they are used to ask questions.

99. **intransitive verb**: a verb that is used to talk about an action or event that only involves the subject and so does not have an object; e.g. *She arrived... I was yawning.*

100. **inversion**: changing the word order in a sentence, especially changing the order of the subject and the verb.

101. **irregular**: not following the normal rules for inflection.

     An irregular verb has a past form and/or *-ed* participle that is formed in a different way from the regular ending.

102. **lexical verb**: another name for **main verb**.

103. **linking verb**: a verb that links the subject and complement of a clause; e.g. *be, become, seem, appear.*

     Also sometimes called **copula**.

104. **main clause**: a clause that is not dependent on, or is not part of, another clause.

105. **main verb**: any verb that is not an auxiliary verb.

     Also called **lexical verb**.

106. **mass noun**: (in this grammar) a noun that is usually an uncountable noun, but that can be used as a countable noun when it refers to quantities or types of something; e.g. *... 2 sugars... cough medicines.*

107. **measurement noun**: a noun that refers to a unit of size, volume, weight, speed, temperature, etc.: e.g. *mile, liter, degree.*

108. **modal**: an auxiliary verb that is used with a main verb to indicate a particular attitude, e.g. possibility, obligation, prediction, or deduction; e.g. *can, could, may, might.*

     Also called *modal auxiliary* or *modal verb.*

109. **modifier**: a word or group of words that come in front of a noun; e.g. *... a beautiful sunny day... a psychology conference.*

110. **negative**: used for describing a sentence that uses a word like *not, never*, or *no one* to indicate the absence or opposite of something, or to say that something is not the case; e.g. *I don't know you... I'll never forget.*

     The opposite is **affirmative**.

111. **negative word**: a word e.g. *never* and *not* which expresses a negative meaning.

112. **nominal relative clause**: a subordinate clause that functions as a noun and often begins with *what* or *whatever*; e.g. *What he said was true.*

113. **nominal *that*-clause**: a subordinate clause that functions as a noun and begins with *that*; e.g. *He showed that it was true.*

114. **non-defining relative clause**: a relative clause that gives more information about someone or something, but that is not needed to identify them; e.g. *That's Mary, who was at university with me.*

     Cf. **defining relative clause**.

115. **non-finite**: the non-finite forms of a verb are the infinitive and participle forms; e.g. *to take, taking, taken.*

116. **noun**: a word that refers to people, things, and abstract ideas e.g. feelings and qualities; e.g. *woman, Harry, guilt.*

117. **noun phrase**: a group of words that acts as the subject, complement, or object of a clause, or as the object of a preposition.

118. **noun modifier**: a noun used in front of another noun, as if it were an adjective; e.g. *. . . a car door. . . a steel works.*

119. **number**: the way in which differences between singular and plural are shown; e.g. *flower/flowers, that/those.*

    See also **cardinal number** and **ordinal number**.

120. **object**: a noun phrase that refers to a person or thing, other than the subject, which is involved in or affected by the action of a verb.

    See also **direct object** and **indirect object**.

    Prepositions are also followed by objects.

121. **object complement**: a word that is used to describe the object of a clause and that occurs with verbs e.g. *make* and *find*; e.g. *It made me tired. . . I found her asleep.*

122. **ordinal number**: a number that is used to indicate where something comes in an order or sequence; e.g. *1st, 5th, 10th, 100th.*

123. **participle**: a verb form used for making different tenses.

    See ***-ed* participle** and ***-ing* participle** for more details.

124. **partitive**: a word that gives information about the amount of a particular thing; e.g. *pint, loaf, portion.*

125. **passive**: verb forms e.g. *was given, were taken, had been made*, where the subject is the person or thing that is affected by the action.

    Cf. **active**.

126. **past form**: the form of a verb, often ending in *-ed*, that is used for the past simple.

127. **past participle**: another name for ***-ed* participle**.

128. **past perfect**: the use of *had* with an *-ed* participle to refer to past events; e.g. *She had finished.*

129. **past perfect progressive**: the use of *had been* with an *-ing* participle to refer to past events; e.g. *He had been waiting for hours.*

    Also called **past perfect continuous**.

130. **past progressive**: the use of *was* or *were* with an *-ing* participle, usually to refer to past events; e.g. *They were worrying about it yesterday.*

    Also called **past continuous**.

131. **past simple**: the use of the past form of a verb to refer to past events; e.g. *They waited. . . It fell over.*

132. **past tense**: a tense used to describe actions or events that took place in the past.

    See **tense** for more details.

133. **perfect form**: a verb form with *have* and an *-ed* participle; e.g. *I have met him. . . We had won.*

134. **performative verb**: a verb that states explicitly what action the speaker is performing when he or she uses it; e.g. *apologize, resign, christen.*

135. **performer**: the person or thing that is responsible for the action expressed by the verb; e.g. *Mark phoned. . . Our dinner was eaten by the dog.*

136. **person**: a term used to refer to the 3 classes of people who are involved in something that is said.

    They are the 1st person (the person speaking or writing), the 2nd person (the person being addressed), and the 3rd person (the person or things that are being talked about).

137. **personal pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *I, you*, and *me* which are used to refer back to the people or things you are talking about.

138. **phrasal verb**: a combination of a verb and an adverb and/or a preposition, which have a single meaning; e.g. *back down, hand over, look after, look forward to.*

139. **phrase**: a set of words that is smaller than a clause, and that is based around a particular word class: e.g., a verb phrase is based around a main verb, and can also contain auxiliary verbs.

    See also **noun phrase, verb phrase** and **prepositional phrase**.

    Phrase is also sometimes used to refer to any group of words.

140. **plural**: the form used to refer to more than 1 person or thing; e.g. *dogs, women.*

141. **plural noun**: a noun that is only used in the plural form; e.g. *trousers, scissors, vermin.*

142. **possessive**: a structure used to show possession; e.g. *your, Jerry's, mine.*

143. **possessive determiner**: a determiner e.g. *my, your*, and *their.*

    Also called **possessive adjective**.

144. **possessive pronoun**: 1 of the words *mine, yours, hers, his, ours*, and *theirs.*

145. **postdeterminer**: a small group of adjectives used after a determiner and in front of other adjectives; e.g. *certain, remaining.*

146. **predeterminer**: a word that comes in front of a determiner; e.g. *all the boys... double the trouble... such a mess.*

147. **predicative**: used for describing the position of adjectives when they are used after a linking verb e.g. 'be'.

    Cf. **attributive**.

148. **preposition**: a word e.g. *by, with* or *from*, which is usually followed by a noun phrase or an *-ing* form.

149. **prepositional phrase**: a structure consisting of a preposition and its object; e.g. *on the table, by the sea.*

150. **present participle**: another name for ***-ing* participle**.

151. **present progressive**: the use of the present simple of 'be' with an *-ing* participle to refer to present events; e.g. *Things are improving.*

    Also called **present continuous**.

152. **present perfect**: the use of the present simple of *have* with an *-ed* participle to refer to past events that exist in the present; e.g. *She has loved him for 10 years.*

153. **present perfect progressive**: the use of *have been* and *has been* with an *-ing* participle to refer to past events that exist in the present; e.g. *We have been sitting here for hours.*

    Also called **present perfect continuous**.

154. **present simple**: the use of the base form or the *s* form of a verb, usually to refer to present events; e.g. *I like bananas... My sister hates them.*

155. **present tense**: a tense used to describe events taking place in the present, or situations that exist in the present.

156. **progressive**: a verb form that contains a form of the verb 'be' and an *-ing* participle; e.g. *She was laughing... They had been playing badminton.*

    Also called **continuous**.

157. **pronoun**: a word used instead of a noun, when you do not want to name someone or something directly; e.g. *it, you, none.*

158. **proper noun**: a noun that refers to a particular person, place, or institution; e.g. *Nigel, Edinburgh, Christmas.*

    Cf. **common noun**.

159. **purpose clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *in order to*, or *so that*;

    e.g. *I came here in order to ask you out to dinner.*

160. **qualifier**: any word, phrase, or clause that comes after a noun phrase, and gives extra information to expand its meaning; e.g. ... *a book with a blue cover* ... *the shop on the corner.*

161. **qualitative adjective**: an adjective that is used to indicate a quality, and is gradable; e.g. *funny, intelligent, small.*

     Cf. **classifying adjective**.

162. **quantity expression**: a phrase ending in *of* that allows you to refer to a quantity of something without being precise about the exact amount; e.g. *some of, a lot of, a little bit of.*

163. **question**: a structure that typically has the verb in front of the subject and that is used to ask someone about something; e.g. *Have you have any money?*

     Also called **interrogative**.

164. **question tag**: a structure or word that is used at the end of a statement in order to form a question.

165. **reason clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *because, since*, or *as*; e.g. *Since you're here, we'll start.*

166. **reciprocal pronoun**: the pronouns *each other* and *one another*, used to show that 2 or more people do or feel the same thing; e.g. *They loved each other.*

167. **reciprocal verb**: a verb that describes an action that involves people affecting each other in the same way with the same action; e.g. *They met in the street... He met her yesterday.*

168. **reflexive pronoun**: a pronoun ending in *-self*, e.g. *myself* or *themselves*, which is used as the object of a verb when the person affected by an action is the same as the person doing it.

169. **reflexive verb**: a verb that is typically used with a reflexive pronoun; e.g. *enjoy yourself; pride yourself on.*

170. **reflexive clause**: a subordinate clause that gives more information about someone or something mentioned in the main clause.

     See also **defining relative clause** and **non-defining relative clause**.

171. **relative pronoun**: a *wh*-word e.g. *who* or *which*, used to introduce a relative clause; e.g. *... the girl who was carrying the bag.*

172. **reported clause**: the part of a reporting structure that describes what someone has said; e.g. *She said that I couldn't see her.*

173. **reported question**: a question that is reported using a reporting structure rather than the exact words used by the speaker.

174. **reported speech**: speech that is reported using a reporting structure rather than the exact words used by the speaker.

     Also called **indirect speech**.

175. **reporting clause**: a clause that contains a reporting verb, which is used to introduce what someone has said; e.g. *They asked if I could come.*

176. **reporting verb**: a verb that describes what people say or think; e.g. *suggest, say, wonder.*

177. **reporting structure**: a structure that reports what someone has said by using a reported clause rather than repeating their exact words; e.g. *She told me she'd be late.*

178. **result clause**: a subordinate clause introduced by *so that* which gives the result of something; e.g. *The house was severely damaged, so that it is now uninhabitable.*

179. **rhetorical question**: a question that you use in order to make a comment rather than to obtain information; e.g. *Oh, isn't it silly?*

180. **second person**: see **person**.

181. **semi-modal**: the verbs *dare, need*, and *used to* which behave rather like modals.

182. **sentence**: a group of words that express a statement, question, or command.

     A sentence usually has a verb and a subject, and may consist of 1 clause, or 2 or more clauses.

     A sentence in writing has a capital letter at the beginning and a full-stop, question mark, or exclamation mark at the end.

183. **sentence adverbial**: an adverbial that applies to the whole clause, rather than to part of it; e.g. *We possibly have to wait and see.*

    See also **sentence connector**.

184. **sentence connector**: a sentence adverbial used to introduce a comment or reinforce what is said; e.g. *moreover, besides.*

185. ***s* form**: the base form of a verb with *s* on the end, used in the present simple.

186. **simple sentence**: a sentence that contains only 1 clause.

187. **singular**: the form used to refer to or talk about 1 person or thing; e.g. *dog, woman.*

    Cf. **plural**.

188. **singular noun**: a noun typically used in the singular form; e.g. *sun, business.*

189. **split infinitive**: the placing of a word between *to* and the base form of a verb; e.g. *... to boldly go where no man has gone before.*

190. **split sentence**: a sentence in which emphasis is given to either the subject or the object by using a structure beginning with *it, what*, or *all*; e.g. *It's a hammer we need... What we need is a hammer.*

191. **stative verb**: a verb that describes a state ; e.g. *be, live, know.*

    Cf. **dynamic verb**.

192. **subject**: a noun phrase that usually comes before a verb, and agrees with the verb in person and number.

    In active sentences, the subject usually refers to the person or thing who dose the action expressed by the verb; e.g. *We were going shopping.*

193. **subjunctive**: a verb form that is used in some languages to express attitudes e.g. wishing, hoping, and doubting.

    The subjunctive is not very common in English, and is used mainly in conditional clauses e.g. *If I were you...*

194. **submodifying adverb**: an adverb that is used in front of an adjective or another adverb in order to strengthen or weaken its meaning; e.g. *... very interesting... quite quickly.*

195. **subordinate clause**: a clause that begins with a subordinating conjunction e.g. *because* or *while* and which must be used with a main clause.

196. **subordinating conjunction**: a conjunction that begins a subordinate clause.

197. **substitution**: the special use of pronouns and other words to replace part or all of a clause; e.g. *'Are you going to the party?' – 'I hope so'.*

198. **superlative**: an adjective or adverb with *-est* on the end or *most* in front of it; e.g. *thinnest, quickest, most wisely.*

199. **tense**: the verb form that shows whether you are referring to the past or the present.

200. ***that*-clause**: a clause starting with '*that*' which is used mainly when reporting what someone has said; e.g. *She said that she'd wash up for me.*

    That can be omitted when the clause is used after a reporting verb.

201. **third person**: see **person**.

202. **time adverbial**: an adverbial that gives more information about when something happens; e.g. *I saw her yesterday.*

203. **time clause**: a subordinate clause that indicates the time of an event; e.g. *I'll phone you when I get back.*

204. **title**: a word used before a person's name to show their position or status; e.g. *Mrs, Lord, Queen.*

205. ***to*-infinitive**: the base form of a verb preceded by *to*; e.g. *to go, to have, to jump.*

206. **transitive verb**: a verb used to talk about an action or event that involves more than 1 person or thing, and so is followed by an object; e.g. *She's wasting her money.*

207. **uncountable noun**: a noun that refers to a general kind of thing rather than to an individual item, and so has only 1 form; e.g. *money, furniture, intelligence.*

     Also called **uncount noun**.

208. **verb**: a word used with a subject to say what someone or something does, or what happens to them; e.g. *sing, spill, die.*

209. **verb phrase**: a main verb, or a main verb preceded by 1 or more auxiliary verbs, which combines with a subject to say what someone or something does, or what happens to them; e.g. *I'll show them... She's been sick.*

210. **vocative**: a word used when speaking to someone, just as if it were their name; e.g. *darling, madam.*

211. ***wh*-clause**: a clause starting with a *wh*-word.

212. ***whether*-clause**: a clause used to report a *yes/no*-question; e.g. *I asked her whether she'd seen him.*

213. ***wh*-question**: a question that expects an answer giving a particular person, place, thing, amount, and so on, rather than just *yes* or *no*.

214. ***wh*-word**: 1 of a group of words starting with *wh*-, e.g. *what, when* or *who*, which are used in *wh*-questions.

     How is also called a *wh*-word because it behaves like the other *wh*-words.

215. ***yes/no*-question**: a question that can be answered simply with either *yes* or *no*; e.g. *Would you like some more tea?*

Chapter 1

Referring to people & things: nouns, pronouns, & determiners

1.1 Introduction to the noun phrase

1.1 At its simplest, language is used to talk about people and things.

People do this by using words in a variety of ways, e.g. to make statements, to ask questions, and to give orders.

The words chosen are arranged into groups, either around a noun or around a verb.

They are called **noun phrases** and **verb phrases**.

Noun phrases tell us which people or things are being talked about.

Verb phrases tell us what is being said about them, e.g. what they are doing.

Chaps. 1–2 of this grammar deal with noun phrases.

For information about verb phrases, see Chap. 3.

1.2 A noun phrase can be the **subject** or **object** of a verb, it can follow a **linking verb**, or it can be the object of a **preposition**.

Example 1.1.1. *Babies cry when they are hungry.*

I couldn't feel anger against him.

They were teachers.

Let us work together in peace.

1.3 You use a noun phrase to talk about someone or something by naming them.

You do this by using a general name, called a **noun** or **common noun**, or by using a specific name, called a **proper noun**.

Proper nouns are mainly used for people, places, and events.

Example 1.1.2. *Mary likes strawberries.*

I went to Drexel University and then I went to Pittsburgh to work for a psychiatrist.

We flew to Genera with British Airways.

See paragraphs **1.52–1.58** for more information about **proper nouns**.

1.4 If you use a common noun, you are saying that the person or thing you are talking about can be put in a set with others that are similar in some way.

If you just want to say that the person or thing is in that set, you use an **indefinite determiner** with the common noun.

Example 1.1.3. *I met a girl who was a student there.*

Have you got any comment to make about that?

There are some diseases that are clearly inherited.

If you want to show which member of a set you are talking about, you use a **definite determiner** with a common noun.

Example 1.1.4. *I put my arm round her shoulders.*

... the destruction of their city.

She came in to see me this morning.

See paragraphs **1.162–1.251** for more information about **determiners**, and paragraphs **1.13–1.92** for more information about **nouns**.

1.5 You may decide not to name the person or thing and to use a **pronoun** rather than a proper noun or common noun.

You usually do this because the person or thing has already been named, so you refer to them by using a **personal pronoun** or a **demonstrative pronoun**.

Example 1.1.5. *Max will believe us, won't he?*
'Could I speak to Sue, please?' - 'I'm sorry, she doesn't work here now.'
Some people have servants to cook for them.
This led to widespread criticism.

See paragraphs **1.95–1.106** for more information about **personal pronouns**, and paragraphs **1.124–1.127** for more information about **demonstrative pronouns**.

1.6 You may decide not to name the person or thing at all, e.g. because you do not want to, you think it is not important, you do not know, or you want to be vague or mysterious while telling a story.

In such cases you use an **indefinite pronoun**, which does not refer to any particular person or thing.

Example 1.1.6. *I had to say something.*
In this country nobody trusts anyone.
A moment later, his heart seemed to stop as he sensed the sudden movement of someone behind him.

See paragraphs **1.128–1.141** for more information about **indefinite pronouns**.

1.7 If you want to give more information about the person or thing you are talking about, rather than just giving their general or specific name, you can use a **modifier** e.g. an **adjective**, or you can add extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause, for example.

1.8 Most **adjectives** are used as modifiers.

Nouns are also often used as modifiers.

Example 1.1.7. *... a big city.*
... blue ink.
He opened the car door.
... the oil industry.

See paragraphs **2.2–2.168** for more information about **adjectives**, and paragraphs **2.169–2.174** for more information about **noun modifiers**.

1.9 You can add a prepositional phrase, a relative clause, a relative clause, an adverb of place of time, or a *to*-infinitive after the noun.

Example 1.1.8. *... a girl in a dark grey dress.*
... the man who employed me.
... the room upstairs.
... the desire to kill.

Adjectives and participles are also sometimes used after the noun, usually in combination with other words.

Example 1.1.9. *... the Minister responsible for national security.*
... the 3 cards lying on the table.

See paragraphs **2.272–2.302** for more details about information that is added after the noun.

1.10 In particular, prepositional phrases beginning with *of* are very common, because they can express many different kinds of relationship between the 2 noun phrases.

Example 1.1.10. *... strong feelings of jealousy.*
... a picture of a house.
... the rebuilding of the old hospital.
... the daughter of the village cobbler.
... problems of varying complexity.
... the arrival of the police.

For more information about the use of *of* in the noun phrase see paragraphs **2.277–2.283**.

1.11 If you want to refer separately to more than 1 person or thing, or you want to describe them in more than 1 way, you link noun phrases using the **conjunctions** *and, or*, or *but*.

Sometimes you use a common instead of *and*, or just put 1 word next to another.

Example 1.1.11. ... *a table and chair.*
... *his obligations with regard to Amanda, Robert and Matthew.*
... *some fruit or cheese afterwards.*
... *her long black skirt.*

See paragraphs **8.171–8.201** for more information about the use of conjunctions to link noun phrases and words within noun phrases.

1.12 If you want to say how many things you are talking about, or how much of something here is, you use **numbers** and **quantity expressions**.

Example 1.1.12. *Last year I worked 7 days a week 14 hours a day.*
She drinks lots of coffee.

Numbers are dealt with in paragraphs **2.208–2.239**, and **quantity expressions** are dealt with in **2.175–2.193**.

1.2 Identifying people & things: nouns

1.13 A noun is used to identity a person or thing.

In this chapter 6 main types of noun are described.

They are classified according to whether they have a plural form, whether they need a determiner in front of them, and whether they occur with a singular verb or a plural verb when they are the subject of the verb.

The 6 types are:

classification: **example**: **comments**: **paragraph**

1. **countable nouns**: a bird, birds: have plural, need determiner: **1.15–1.22**
2. **uncountable nouns**: happiness equipment: no plural, usually no determiner: **1.23–1.33**
3. **singular nouns**: the moon, a day: no plural, need determiner: **1.34–1.40**
4. **plural nouns**: clothes scissors: no singular: **1.41–1.46**
5. **collective nouns**: the public, the staff: either singular or plural verb: **1.47–1.51**
6. **proper nouns**: Mary, London, The United Nations: start with capital letter: **1.52–1.58**

Many nouns have a number of different meanings, and so can be, e.g., a countable noun for 1 meaning, an uncountable noun for another, and a singular noun for another.

There are few other groups of nouns with special features.

These are dealt with in paragraphs **1.59–1.92**.

1.14 Most nouns do not begin with a capital letter, unless they are used to start a sentence.

However, the following types of noun are always spelled with a capital letter:

- **proper nouns** or names

  Example 1.2.1. ... *my sister Elizabeth.*

  I love reading Shakespeare.

  I'll be in the office on Monday.

  I think he's gone to London.

  For more information on proper nouns, see paragraphs **1.52–1.58**.

  Proper nouns that are time expressions are dealt with a Chap. 4, and those that are place names in Chap. 6.

- nouns that identify people of a particular nationality, or languages

  Example 1.2.2. *Can you think of some typical problems experienced by Germans learning English?*

- nouns that are the name of a particular product

  Example 1.2.3. *He drives a Porsche.*

  Put a bit of Sellotape across it.

1.2.1 Things that can be counted: countable nouns

1.15 Many nouns have 2 forms, the **singular** form, which is used to refer to 1 person or thing, and the **plural** form, which is used to refer to more than 1 person or thing.

These nouns refer to people or things that can be counted.

You can put numbers in front of them.

Example 1.2.4. ... *book*... *books*.
... *day*... *days*.
... *3 brothers*.
... *10 minutes*.

These nouns make up the largest group of nouns in English.

They are called **countable nouns**.

1.16 When you use the singular form of a countable noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular verb.

When you use the plural form of a countable noun as the subject, you use a plural verb.

Example 1.2.5. *A dog likes to eat far more meat than a human being.*
Bigger dogs cost more.

1.17 Countable nouns have a determiner in front of them when they are used in the singular.

Example 1.2.6. *He got into the car and started the motor.*
They left the house to go for a walk after lunch.

When you use the plural form of a countable noun to talk about something in general, you do not use a determiner.

Example 1.2.7. *They all live in big houses.*
Most classrooms have computers.

However, if you are specifying a particular instance of something, you need to use a determiner.

Example 1.2.8. *The houses in our street are all identical.*
Our computers can give you all the relevant details.

1.18 Here is a list of some common countable nouns:

Example 1.2.9. *accident, account, actor, address, adult, animal, answer, apartment, article, artist, baby, bag, ball, bank, battle, beach, bed, bell, bill, bird, boat, book, bottle, box, boy, bridge, brother, bus, bush, camp, captain, car, card, case, castle, cat, chair, chapter, chest, child, cigarette, city, class, club, coat, college, computer, corner, country, crowd, cup, daughter, day, desk, doctor, dog, door, dream, dress, driver, ear, edge, effect, egg, election, engine, eye, face, factory, farm, father, field, film, finger, foot, friend, game, garden, gate, girl, group, gun, hall, hand, handle, hat, head, heart, hill, horse, hospital, hotel, hour, house, husband, idea, island, issue, job, journey, judge, key, king, kitchen, lady, lake, library, line, list, machine, magazine, man, meal, meeting, member, message, method, minute, mistake, model, month, motor, mouth, nation, neck, newspaper, office, page, park, party, path, picture, plan, plane, plant, problem, product, programme, project, ring, river, road, room, scheme, school, ship, shirt, shock, shop, sister, smile, son, spot, star, station, store, stream, street, student, table, task, teacher, tent, thought, tour, town, valley, village, walk, wall, week, window, woman, yard, year*

Note that many of these nouns have some meanings in which they are uncountable nouns, but they are countable nouns in their commonest meanings.

1.19 For most countable nouns the plural form has *-s* at the end, which distinguishes it from the singular form.

Example 1.2.10. ... *bed*... *beds*.
... *car*... *cars*.

Some countable nouns have other differences between the singular and plural forms.

Example 1.2.11. ... *bus*... *buses*.
... *lady*... *ladies*.
... *calf*... *calves*.
... *man*... *men*.
... *mouse*... *mice*.

For full information about the plural forms of countable nouns, see the Reference section.

1.20 Some countable nouns have the same form for both singular and plural.

Example 1.2.12. *... a sheep.*
... 9 sheep.

Many of these nouns refer to animals or fish; others are more varied in meaning:

Example 1.2.13. *bison, deer, elk, greenfly, grouse, moose, reindeer, sheep*
cod, fish, goldfish, halibut, mullet, salmon, shellfish, trout, whitebait
aircraft, hovercraft, spacecraft
crossroads, dice, fruit, gallows, grapefruit, insignia, mews, offspring, series, species
bourgeois, chassis, corps, patois, précis, rendezvous

1.21 The names of many animals and birds have 2 forms, one singular and one plural.
However, when you are referring to them in the context of hunting or when you are saying that there are large numbers of them, it is quite common to use the form without *-s*, even though you are referring to several animals or birds.

Example 1.2.14. *We went up north to hunt deer.*

Note that the plural form of the verb is used when several animals or birds are the subject of the sentence, even if you use the form without *-s*.

Example 1.2.15. *Zebra are a more difficult prey.*

Similarly, when you are referring to a large number of trees or plants growing together, you can use the singular form of their name.
When you are referring to a small number or to individual trees or plants, you usually use the form with *-s*.

Example 1.2.16. *Zebra are a more difficult prey.*

Similarly, when you are referring to a large number of trees or plants growing together, you can use the singular form of their name.
When you are referring to a small number or to individual trees or plants, you usually use the form with *-s*.

Example 1.2.17. *... the rows of willow and cypress which lined the creek.*
... the poplars and willows along the Peshawar Road.

1.22 [**Be creative**] Although some names of animals, birds, trees, and plants are commonly used in the singular form with plural meaning, in fact all such names can be used in this way.

1.2.2 Things not usually counted: uncountable nouns

1.23 Some nouns refer to general things e.g. qualities, substances, processes, and topics rather than to individual items or events.
These nouns have only 1 form, are not used with numbers, and are not usually used with the determiners *the, a*, or *an*.

Example 1.2.18. *... a boy or girl with intelligence.*
Make sure everyone has enough food and drink.
... new techniques in industry and agriculture.
I talked with people about religion, death, marriage, money, and happiness.

These nouns are called **uncountable nouns**.
1.24 When you use an uncountable noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular form of the verb.

Example 1.2.19. *Love makes you do strange things.*
They believed that poverty was a threat to world peace.
Electricity is potentially dangerous.

1.25 Here is a list of some common uncountable nouns:

Example 1.2.20. *absence, access, age, agriculture, anger, atmosphere, beauty, behavior, cancer, capacity, childhood, china, comfort, concern, confidence, courage, death, democracy, depression, design, duty, earth, education, electricity, energy, environment, equipment, evil, existence, experience, failure, faith, fashion, fear, finance, fire, flesh, food, freedom, fun, ground, growth, happiness, health, help, history, ice, independence, industry, insurance, intelligence, joy, justice, labor, loneliness, love, luck, magic, marriage, mercy, music, nature, paper, patience, peace, philosophy, pleasure, policy, poverty, power, pride, protection, purity, rain, reality, refief, religion, respect, rice, safety, salt, sand, security, silence, sleep, strength, snow, spite, status, stuff, teaching, technology, time, trade, training, transport, travel, trust, truth, violence, waste, water, wealth, weather, welfare, wind, work, worth, youth*

[!]
1.26 There are some words that are uncountable nouns in English, but that refer to things that are considered countable in other languages.

Here is a list of the most common uncountable nouns of this type:

Example 1.2.21. *advice, baggage, furniture, hair, homework, information, knowledge, luggage, machinery, money, news, progress, research, spaghetti, traffic*

1.27 Although uncountable nouns refer to things that cannot be counted and are not used with numbers, you often want to talk about an amount of something that is expressed by an uncountable noun.

Sometimes, you can do this by putting an **indefinite determiner** e.g. *all, enough, little*, or *some* in front of the noun.

Example 1.2.22. *Do you have enough money?*
There's some chocolate cake over there.

For more information on indefinite determiners that can be used with uncountable nouns, see paragraph **1.225**.

You can also put a **quantity expression** in front of the noun.

E.g., when you refer to water you can say *drops of water, a cup of water, 4 gallons of water*, and so on.

The use of quantity expressions with uncountable nouns is explained in paragraphs **2.194**–**2.207**.

1.28 When you are sure that your reader or hearer will understand that a quantity of something is being referred to, you do not need to use a quantity expression.

E.g., in a restaurant you can ask for *3 cups of coffee*, but you can also ask for *3 coffees* because the person you are talking to will know that you mean *3 cups of coffee*.

In this way, the uncountable noun *coffee* has become countable.

Nouns used in this way are called **mass nouns**.

1.29 Mass nouns are often used to refer to quantities of a particular kind of food or drink.

Example 1.2.23. *We spent 2 hours talking over coffee and biscuits in her study.*
We stopped for a coffee at a small café.

1.30 Similarly, some uncountable nouns can be mass nouns when they refer to types of something,

E.g., *cheese* is usually an uncountable noun but you can talk about *a large range of cheeses*.

Example 1.2.24. *... plentiful cheap beer.*
... profits from low-alcohol beers.
We were not allowed to buy wine or spirits at lunch time.
We shell a wide variety of wines and liqueurs.

Mass nouns referring to different types of a substance are mainly used in technical contexts.

E.g. *steel* is nearly always an uncountable noun, but in contexts where it is important to distinguish between different kinds of steel it can be a mass noun.

Example 1.2.25. *... imports of European steel.*
... the use of small amounts of nitrogen in making certain steels.

1.31 The following is a list of frequency used mass nouns:

Example 1.2.26. *adhesive, beer, brandy, bread, cake, cheese, claret, cloth, coal, coffee, cognac, coke, cotton, curry, deodorant, detergent, disinfectant, dye, fabric, fertilizer, fuel, fur, fin, glue, ink, insecticide, iron, jam, jelly, juice, lager, liqueur, lotion, material, meat, medicine, metal, milk, oil, ointment, ore, paint, perfume, pesticide, plastic, poison, preservative, ribbon, salad, sauce, sherry, soap, soil, soup, steel, sugar, tea, vodka, whisky, wine, wood, wool, yarn, yoghurt*

1.32 There are also some other nouns that can be uncountable nouns when they refer to a thing in general, and countable nouns when they refer to a particular instance of it.

Some nouns are commonly both uncountable nouns and countable nouns.

E.g., *victory* refers to the idea of winning in general but *a victory* refers to a particular occasion when someone wins.

Example 1.2.27. *He worked long and hard and finally led his team to victory.*
... his victory in the Australian Grand Prix.
Many parents were alarmed to find themselves in open conflict with the church.
Hundreds of people have died in ethnic conflicts.

Some uncountable nouns are rarely or never countable nouns; i.e., they do not occur in a plural form, or with a number.

Example 1.2.28. *... a collection of fine furniture.*
We found Alan weeping with relief and joy.
He saved money by refusing to have a telephone.

1.33 Some nouns that end in *-s* and look as if they are plural are in fact uncountable nouns.
This means that when they are the subject of a verb, the verb is in the singular.
These nouns refer mainly to subjects to study, activities, games, and diseases.

Example 1.2.29. *Physics is fun.*
Politics plays a large part in village life.
Economics is the oldest of the social sciences.
Darts is a very competitive sport.
Measles is in most cases a relatively harmless disease.

Here are 3 lists of uncountable nouns ending in *-s*.
These nouns refer to subjects of study and activities:

Example 1.2.30. *acoustics, aerobics, aerodynamics, aeronautics, athletics, classics, economics, electronics, genetics, gymnastics, linguistics, logistics, mathematics, mechanics, obstetrics, physics, politics, statistics, thermodynamics*

Note that some of these nouns are occasionally used as plural nouns, especially when you are talking about a particular person's work or activities.

Example 1.2.31. *His politics are clearly right-wing.*

These nouns refer to games:

Example 1.2.32. *billiards, bowls, cards, darts, draughts, skittles, tiddlywinks*

These nouns refer to diseases:

Example 1.2.33. *diabetes, measles, mumps, rabies, rickets, shingles*

1.2.3 When there is only 1 of something: singular nouns

1.34 There are certain things in the world that are unique.
There are other things that you almost always want to talk about one at a time.
This means that there are some nouns, or more often some meanings of nouns, for which only a singular form is used.
When a noun is used with such a meaning, it is called a **singular noun**.
Singular nouns are always used with a determiner, because they behave like the singular form of a countable noun.
1.35 When you use a singular noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular form of the verb.

Example 1.2.34. *The sun was shining.*
The atmosphere is very relaxed.

1.36 Some singular nouns refer to 1 specific thing and therefore are used with the.
Some of these nouns, in fact, refer to something of which there is only one in the world.

Example 1.2.35. *There were huge cracks in the ground.*
The moon had not yet reached my window.
Burning tanks threw great spirals of smoke into the air.
He's always thinking about the the past and worrying about the future.

1.37 Other singular nouns can be used to refer to 1 thing only when it is obvious from the context what you are referring to.
E.g., if you are in Leeds and say *I work at the university*, you will almost certainly mean Leeds University.
However, in the following examples it is not clear exactly who or what the singular noun refers to, because there is not enough context.

Example 1.2.36. *In many countries the market is small numerically.*
Their company looks good only because the competition looks bad.
You've all missed the point.

Unless it is made clear which goods or products are being talked about, it is not possible for the reader or listener to be sure which group of potential buyers *the market* refers to.

Similarly it is not possible to know exactly which company or group of companies *the competition* refers to.

In the last example, the speaker is presumably going to state what he or she thinks *the point* is.

1.38 There are some activities that you do not usually do more than once at a time.

The nouns that refer to them are usually the object of a verb, and are used with the determiner *a*.

In this structure the verb has very little meaning and the noun carries most of the meaning of the whole structure.

For more information about these verb + object idioms, see paragraphs **3.32–3.45**.

Example 1.2.37. *I went and had a wash.*
Bruno gave it a try.

Some singular nouns are used so regularly with a particular verb that they have become fixed phrases and are idiomatic.

Example 1.2.38. *I'd like very much for you to have a voice in the decision.*
Isn't it time we made a move?

1.39 There are 2 special kinds of structure in which a singular noun is used.

A singular noun is sometimes used with the determiner *a* after a linking verb.

See paragraphs **3.126–3.181** for more information about **linking verbs**.

Example 1.2.39. *Decision-making is an art.*
The quickest way was by using the car.
It was a risk but he decided it had to be taken.
They were beginning to find Griffiths' visits rather a strain.

A singular noun is sometimes used with the determiner *the*, followed by a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*.

Example 1.2.40. *Comedy is the art of making people laugh.*
Old machines will be replaced by newer ones to reduce the risk of breakdown.
He collapsed under the strain of a heavy workload.

This group includes nouns used metaphorically; see paragraph **1.64** for more details.

Some singular nouns are always used to refer to 1 particular quality or thing, but are rarely used alone; i.e., they need to be specified in some way by the use of supporting material.

They can be used with a number of different determiners.

Example 1.2.41. *There was a note of satisfaction in his voice.*
Bessie covered the last 50 yards at a tremendous pace.
Simon allowed his pace to slacken.
She was simply incapable of behaving in a rational and considered manner.
... their manner of rearing their young.

Nouns that are rarely used alone without supporting material are discussed in detail in paragraphs **1.59–1.65**.

[i] Usage note.

1.40 Some nouns are used in the singular with a particular meaning only in an idiomatic phrase.

They have the appearance of singular nouns, but they are not used as freely as singular nouns.

Example 1.2.42. *What happens down there is none of my business.*
It's a pity I can't get to him.

1.2.4 Referring to more than 1 thing: plural nouns

1.41 There are some things that are considered to be plural rather than singular, so some nouns have only a plural form.

E.g., you buy *goods*, but not *a good*.

These nouns are called **plural nouns**.

Other nouns have only a plural form when they are used with a particular meaning.

E.g., an official meeting between American and Russian leaders is usually referred to as *talks* rather than as *a talk*.

In these meanings, these nouns are also called **plural nouns**.

Example 1.2.43. *Union leaders met the company for wage talks on Oct 9.*
It is inadvisable to sell goods on a sale or return basis.
Take care of your clothes.
The weather conditions were the same.
All proceeds are going to charity.
Employees can have meals on the premises.

Note that some plural nouns do not end in *-s*: e.g. *clergy, police, poultry*, and *vermin*.

1.42 When you use a plural noun as the subject of a verb, you use plural form of the verb.

Example 1.2.44. *Expenses for attending meetings are sometimes claimed.*
The foundations were shaking.
Refreshments were on sale in the café.
Attempts were made where resources were available.

1.43 You do not usually use numbers in front of plural nouns.

You can, however, use some **indefinite determiners** e.g. *some* or *many*.

For more information about the indefinite determiners that can be used with plural nouns, see the section beginning at paragraph **1.223**.

Some plural nouns usually have a definite determiner in front of them, because they are specific; some never have a determiner at all, because they are very general; and some are rarely used alone without extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause, e.g., because they need supporting material.

The lists in the following 2 paragraphs contain some common plural nouns that are frequently used in 1 of these ways.

Many of them have other meanings in which they are countable nouns.

1.44 Some plural nouns are most commonly used with *the*.

Example 1.2.45. *Things are much worse when the rains come.*
The authorities are concerned that the cocaine may be part of an international drug racket.
The coach tour of Gran Canaria was a wonderfully relaxing way to see the sights.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used with *the*:

Example 1.2.46. *authorities, foundations, fruits, heavens, mains, odds, pictures, races, rains, sights, waters, wilds*

Some plural nouns are most commonly used with a possessive determiner e.g. *my* or *his*:

Example 1.2.47. *It offended her feelings.*
My travels up the Dalmation coast began in Dubrovnik.
This only added to his troubles.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used with a possessive determiner:

Example 1.2.48. *activities, attentions, feelings, likes, movements, reactions, terms, travels, troubles, wants*

Some plural nouns are most commonly used without a determiner.

Example 1.2.49. *There were 1 or 2 cases where people returned goods.*
There is only 1 applicant, which simplifies matters.
They treated us like vermin.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used without a determiner:

Example 1.2.50. *airs, appearances, events, expenses, figures, goods, matters, refreshments, riches, solids, talks, vermin*

Some plural nouns can be used both with or without determiners.

Example 1.2.51. *The house was raided by police.*
We call the police.
A luxury hotel was to be used as headquarters.
The city has been his headquarters for 5 years.
We didn't want it to dampen spirits which were required to remain positive.
The last few miles really lifted our spirits.

Here is a list of plural nouns that can be used with or without a determiner:

Example 1.2.52. *arms, basics, brains, clergy, costs, directions, essentials, greens, grounds, handcuffs, headquarters, interests, looks, means, morals, papers, particulars, people, police, poultry, premises, proceeds, rates, resources, specifics, spirits, supplies, talks, thanks, tracks, troops, values*

1.45 Some plural nouns are rarely used alone without a modifier, or some other form of extra information, because they need supporting material.

Example 1.2.53. *He doesn't tolerate bad manners.*
Our country's coastal defences need improving.
. . . the hidden pressures of direct government funding.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are rarely used alone without a modifier or some other extra information:

Example 1.2.54. *affairs, conditions, defences, demands, details, effects, forces, hopes, lines, manners, materials, matters, pressures, proportions, quarters, relations, remains, sands, services, thoughts, wastes, ways, words, works, writings*

1.46 2 special groups of nouns are usually plural: nouns referring to clothes and some other things that people wear, and nouns referring to tools and some other things that people use.
This is because some clothes and tools, e.g. *trousers* and *scissors*, are made up of 2 similar parts.

Example 1.2.55. *She wore brown trousers and a green sweater.*
He took off his glasses.
. . . using the pliers from the toolbox.

When you want to refer to these items in general, or to an unspecified number of them, you use the plural form with no determiner.

Example 1.2.56. *Never poke scissors into a light bulb socket.*
The man was watching the train through binoculars.

Here is a list of some plural nouns that refer to clothes and other things that people wear:

Example 1.2.57. *braces, briefs, cords, dungarees, glasses, jeans, jodhpurs, knickers, leggings, overalls, panties, pants, pyjamas, shorts, slacks, specs, spectacles, sunglasses, tights, trousers, trunks, underpants*

Here is a list of plural nouns that refer to tools and other things that people use:

Example 1.2.58. *binoculars, clippers, compasses, dividers, nutcrackers, pincers, pliers, scales, scissors, secateurs, shears, tongs, tweezers*

When you want to refer to a single piece of clothing or a single tool, you use *some* or *a pair of* in front of the noun.
You refer to more than 1 item by using a number or a quantity expression with *pairs of*.

Example 1.2.59. *I got some scissors out of the kitchen drawer.*
I went out to buy a pair of scissors.
He was wearing a pair of old grey trousers.
Liza has 3 pairs of jeans.

You can also use *a pair of* when you are talking about things e.g. gloves, shoes, and socks that typically occur in twos.

Example 1.2.60. *. . . a pair of new gloves.*

A possessive determiner e.g. *my* can be used instead of *a*.

Example 1.2.61. *. . . his favorite pair of shoes.*

When you use *a pair of* with a noun in the plural form, the verb is singular if it is in the same clause.
If the verb is in a following relative clause, it is usually plural.

Example 1.2.62. *It is likely that a new pair of shoes brings more happiness to a child than a new car brings to a grown-up.*
I always wear a pair of long pants underneath, or a pair of pyjamas is just as good.
He put on a pair of brown shoes, which were waiting there for him.
He wore a pair of earphones, which were plugged into a radio.

You use a plural pronoun after *a pair of*.

Example 1.2.63. *She went to the wardrobe, chose a pair of shoes, put them on and leaned back in the chair.*
He brought out a pair of dark glasses and handed them to Walker.

1.2.5 Referring to groups: collective nouns

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